reality of a divided polity. There are only two ways that an analyst can see India restoring a coherent, unified and effective strategy for the subcontinent given its geographic, historic and cultural reality. One is by being powerful enough to impose its security perspective on other countries in the subcontinent in the manner of a Pax Indica. The other is by designing political, economic, cultural and security policies to create a web of interdependencies. These approaches can help the country work around, though not erase, the existing subcontinental political boundaries. If it chooses to create a web of interdependencies, India could take advantage of its size and its asymmetrical strengths vis-à-vis its neighbours to achieve a level of interconnectedness that would render borders irrelevant.

The positive experience of dense engagement and productive cooperation would, over time, create a common strategic perspective encompassing the subcontinent as a whole and be reflected in a shared regional identity and the pursuit of shared political, economic and security interests vis-à-vis the rest of the world. At least that is the hope. Whatever be the approach – overwhelming dominance or cooperative engagement – the enduring challenge is the same, though it has manifested in different ways during different historical phases. India's challenge is to transform the contested territory into one aligned with its own more expansive and expanding global objectives. The status of being the largest country in the subcontinent still resonates with the mental map that lies embedded in India's consciousness. There is a constant effort, even if only at the subconscious level, to rise above the political divisions in the subcontinent so that the ancient geography becomes whole again.

There is another unique element in India's world view that is shaped by its geography and history. India is a classic example of crossroads culture. Its peninsular character put it astride the major maritime routes dictated by the monsoon winds, both east and west. It also lay at the intersection of caravan routes linking Central Asia and China to distant nations in the Mediterranean. Its traders were a familiar sight in ancient Greece and Rome, as they were in South East Asia and China. When Ashoka sent Buddhist missions to foreign countries in the third century BCE , he was